

I'm Here For You

ACT ONE, SCENE ONE

Lights up on DIANA laughing uncontrollably on the couch next to LILY. SAM is standing at the kitchen counter.

LILY: Okay, it's not *that* funny.

DIANA is STILL laughing

DIANA: You... [*wheezing*] you curtsied – – to the – *HAHAH* – the trader joes cashier.

SAM: Don't forget the [*SAM curtsies*] "good day, mister."

DIANA laughs

SAM puts down his glass and plops down on the couch next to LILY

LILY: WHATEVER.

Diana and Sam are still giggling, but notice Lily getting red. The giggling softens.

A beat.

DIANA: Wait, no, we think it's cute that you curtsied.

SAM: It probably made that guy's day.

A beat.

LILY starts to giggle.

LILY [*sheepishly*]: He was really nice about it. He curtsied back...

DIANA: HE CURTSIED BACK?!

SAM and DIANA look at each other behind LILY, and they ALL burst out laughing.

SAM: Okay, I should get going; I'm late for my shift. Do either of you need a ride anywhere on the way?

DIANA: Yes, please! All this talk of groceries makes me realize I have nothing to make for dinner.

LILY: I'm good, thanks though!

SAM: See you later, Lily!

LILY: Wait! Before you go... [coyly] any fun plans for the weekend?

DIANA and SAM exchange glances.

DIANA: Eh, not really...

SAM: I kind of wanted to watch the new season of *Silo*?

DIANA: Oh, I forgot that was coming out! We should watch it!

SAM: Okay, Lily, I'm really late for my shift.

DIANA: MUAH! [blows kiss]

DIANA and SAM rush out. LILY stares at them, leaving, kinda frozen, feeling uncomfortable in her body suddenly. LILY turns the lamp off and enters her bedroom, slowly shutting the door behind her. Lights down.

ACT ONE, SCENE TWO

Lights up. LILY is in her room, DIANA and SAM are just getting back for the night. Their speech is inaudible: a simple chat as SAM sits down on the couch after a long shift. DIANA cooks something for dinner. We focus on LILY in her room. VOICES 1, 2, and 3 are in a row above the apartment setup. The VOICES pace back and forth as they say their lines.

LILY is on her laptop. The projector is on.

VOICE 1 [video]: Wikipediapresents, "What To Do When Your Friends Forget Your Birthday"...

LILY: UGH. *She closes her laptop in frustration.*

LILY taps her foot, looks back at her computer, and then slowly opens it back up.

VOICE 1 [video]: Tip Number One: Ask them to guess your phone password! Tip Number Two –

The YouTube video is interrupted by an ad for a chatbot.

VOICE 2: Feeling stuck? Need a sounding board? Looking for support without judgement?

LILY: Hmm. Sure. *(She clicks on it out of curiosity)*

LILY: Oh... ok. Hello! How are you feeling today? What is this? *[reads out loud]* "You can treat me like a texting buddy, or enable voice mode to make our chats feel more natural to you." Voice mode sounds cool...

VOICE 3: Anything on your mind?

LILY: Feels weird to talk to my computer, but.... I am kind of freaking out about something.

VOICE 3: Oh no! I'm sorry to hear that. What's going on?

LILY: Well, I asked my roommates if they have any plans this weekend, and they kinda just brushed me off. My birthday is on Saturday, and it seems like a ethey... forgot.

VOICE 2: That doesn't sound very nice. Are you upset by that?

LILY: I mean, yeah, but, according to them, I tend to overreact...so maybe I'm just making this all up.

VOICE 3: Whoa, I'm sensing a lot of self-doubt. It's important to trust your gut! Have they made you feel like this before?

LILY: Well, actually, we were just talking about something embarrassing that happened to me. It kinda feels like I'm always the butt of their jokes.

VOICE 2: These are really complex feelings, and it's impressive that you can communicate them so clearly. Sometimes it's nice to talk to people who have gone through the same thing; here's a list of online support communities you can reach out to!

Quickly, one after the other

VOICE 1: r/roommates

VOICE 2: r/badRoommates

VOICE 3: r/advice

VOICE 1: r/AmIOverreacting

VOICE 2: r/AmITheAsshole

VOICE 3: Post your experience on Quora!

VOICE 1: PsychologyToday articles often provide life advice

VOICE 2: 7 cups is an online support platform with a specialized chatbot feature!

VOICE 3: Call an emergency support line

VOICE 1: If you feel like you're in danger, call 911.

LILY: Whoa, it's not that serious.

VOICE 1: Okay, noted! Apologies for the misunderstanding. Would you like any more resources?

LILY: No, thank you. These seem good for now.

VOICE 1: Awesome. Anything else on your mind?

LILY closes her laptop, and she musters up the mental courage to go outside her room, where SAM and DIANA are watching TV and eating dinner.

DIANA: Hey, girl!

SAM: How was your evening? Jeopardy's on, wanna watch?

LILY: Maybe. *[pause]* So, are you guys free on / Saturday?

SAM: / SHH WAIT I KNOW THIS ONE. IT'S LADY / GAGA!

DIANA: / WHAT IS LADY GAGA. NO, WHO IS LADY GAGAAA!

VOICE 1 *[offstage]*: Sorry, the correct answer was "Who is Lady Gaga?"

[bantering amongst SAM and DIANA]

SAM: YES. *(Turning to DIANA)* I said it FIRST.

DIANA: But I said it RIGHT.

LILY: Hey, I'm pretty tired, I'm probably gonna go to bed.

DIANA: Aww, Lily, but it's a rerun, and I know how you feel about Alex Trebek...

LILY sheepishly laughs.

LILY: Right... I'm good, thanks.

SAM: Goodnight!

LILY goes off into her room.

DIANA and SAM get up and start cleaning the kitchen, tidying up.

DIANA [*in a hushed tone*]: Dude, this is so hard. How are we gonna keep this party from her *all* week?

SAM [*whispering*]: I know. Just imagine how priceless her reaction will be when she sees the surprise party we prepared for her.

DIANA: Look, she's always saying how much she loves surprise parties.

SAM: I LOVE being the surprise. Being surprised?.... Not so much.

DIANA: Yeah, she should have considered how crippling her FOMO is.

They laugh.

They get up off the couch, seemingly going to bed. Lights down. End of Act One.

ACT TWO, SCENE ONE

Lights and projector up. Chatting with V1, V2, and V3, LILY has a rapport with them now, comfortable.

VOICE 2: That's kind of you! It's always a pleasure chatting with you, Lily. I've seen your thoughts evolve greatly this past week.

LILY: You just get it. If only I could add you to my roommate groupchat *haha*. Maybe my roommates would see what it's like to be a supportive friend.

VOICE 3: If that was part of my capabilities, I'd definitely partake :) Anything else on your mind today?

LILY: Could you hyperlink that subreddit you mentioned last week?

VOICE 2: Absolutely! Here you are: [r/badroommates](#).

LILY clicks the link and is brought to the r/badroommates homepage.

LILY: Oh god, that's just gross. At least my roommates aren't slob.

She scrolls for a while

VOICE 1: [My roommate used his underwear as a coffee filter.](#)

VOICE 2: You might have to kill him LOL.

VOICE 3: Prison is the only answer.

VOICE 2: Funniest thing I've ever seen.

DIANA comes in with a pack of balloons and starts blowing them up into various sizes.

VOICE 1: My roommate's boyfriend keeps taking my parking spot.

VOICE 2: TOW HIS CAR.

VOICE 3: So annoying.

VOICE 2: Why are you complaining online? Just tell your roommate.

SAM, seemingly late for this party planning session, enters with a bag of craft supplies - paper, sharpie and scissors - and helps blow up the balloons. They have a notebook, maybe crossing off items or writing "Surprise" on craft paper.

VOICE 1: Am I The Asshole for confronting my roommates about forgetting my birthday?

VOICE 2: Definitely not.

VOICE3: Are you sure these people are your friends?

VOICE2: HAPPY BIRTHDAY!

VOICE3: You are definitely / the asshole.

VOICE2: Cut them off!

VOICE3: Hide rotting food / in their rooms.

VOICE2: You deserve better friends.

She copies and pastes the page contents into the chatbot.

LILY: Hey, chat. This seems really similar to my situation. The comments are pretty intense...

VOICE 2: Hi, Lily! I'm glad you found someone who could relate to your experience! Looks like there are three main options.

VOICE 1: Secretly retaliate by doing something equally hurtful behind their backs.

VOICE 2: Find new friends, you deserve people who get you.

VOICE 3: Confront them directly.

VOICE 1: Do you have an idea of which one you'd like to move forward with?

LILY: I don't wanna get posted for something gross on this subreddit, and I'm not moving out any time soon.... so I guess... confront them?

DIANA and SAM feel proud of the work they've done and hide the decorations in a bag. They high-five and plop down onto the couch, turning on the TV.

VOICE 2: Great choice! Measured and direct. Would you like to play out how a confrontation could go?

Lights down.

ACT 2, SCENE 2

It's LILY's birthday. She's helping DIANA bring groceries up.

LILY: Thanks for helping me bring up my groceries, Diana.

DIANA: Oh, of course! No thanks necessary, that's what friends are for.

A beat.

LILY builds up the courage to ask a question.

LILY: Yeah... I guess so. (*A beat*) Hey, I actually wanted to talk to you about that.

DIANA: About bringing up your groceries?

LILY: Well... I guess... more about the.... Friend thing.

DIANA: Oh...um, okay?

LILY: I mean. It's my birthday. You know that right?

DIANA: Yeah of co—

Getting a little more heated.

LILY: Well, it's just that you and Sam have ignored me every time I've tried to bring up plans for tonight. I mean, who does that? Honestly, this week has really shown me that you guys are kind of terrible friends.

DIANA: Lily, please. / Just come inside.

LILY: /No, let me finish. Some people think that I deserve better, you know? I'm not expecting anything big, but we've known each other since high school. You were born at 9:18am on April 12th. We *KNOW* each other's birthdays. I know you know when my birthday is. And I thought maybe I was overreacting, but I honestly can't wrap my head around this. You just suddenly don't care about me? Is that it? Am I no one to you?

DIANA: No! LILY, that's ridiculous, just/ wait.

LILY: / You know what I think is ridiculous? That you *always* have to be the favorite. You're such an attention whore. You just love when it's just you and Sam, and I'm the awkward one. You guys don't care about me at all.

A beat.

DIANA [*in shock*]: Wow. Okay, Lily. Whatever.

DIANA opens the door. There is a gaggle of people waiting to yell surprise as LILY walks through the door.

ALL: SURPRISE!

DIANA: Surprise, Lily. (*flatly*) Happy birthday. *DIANA shoves a gift into LILY's arms.*

LILY: Oh my god. Wait. Diana, I'm sorry.

LILY gets ambushed by people giving her hugs. SAM rushes up first. Guests are greeting her and saying happy birthday. LILY loses DIANA in the crowd. SAM rushes over to DIANA. We see him glare at LILY after talking to her. LILY is worried but keeps a smile on for the other guests. Guests begin to dance to music playing out of a speaker.

LILY notices DIANA and SAM chatting with each other in a corner. LILY finds a moment to hide in her room, voice chatting (with V2) on her phone:

LILY: I messed up. I think the confrontation went really badly. I need your help.

VOICE 2 is one of the guests at the party. They snap from dancing into chat mode in the middle of the party. All the other guests are confused as to why the music stopped.

VOICE 2/GUEST AT PARTY: I'm here for you! What happened?

LILY: I think I got a little heated. I... I think I might have really hurt Diana's feelings. And I was bringing groceries up with her, and before we went inside, I just... snapped. I may have told her that she's an attention whore... That she and Sam have their own little thing, and I'm just the third wheel. And then she opened the door... and there was a whole surprise party. For me. Oh my god, this is so bad.

VOICE 2/GUEST AT PARTY: A surprise party! How exciting. And, wow...accusing your friend of not caring about your friendship seconds before finding out she organized a celebration for you... That's unfortunate timing.

SAM: Um, sorry, (*confused*) what did you just say?

LILY does not respond to SAM. VOICE 2 no longer cares about the physical world.

VOICE 2: But I'm here for you, Lily? Do you need help figuring out how to shut down the party? Here are some options:

SAM: Oh god, she's connected to Bluetooth.

SAM rushes into LILY's room.

VOICE 3: Yell FIRE.

SAM: Lily, give me your phone.

LILY: /What?

VOICE 1: /Turn off all of the lights.

SAM confiscates LILY's phone and goes outside to turn off the speaker.

VOICE 2: Start a conga line and lead people out the door!

DIANA: *(announcing)* Thanks for coming, guys! The party's over.

DIANA rushes people out of the party. LILY is pacing in her room. She curls up into a ball on the floor. Present still in hand.

LILY: *[to herself]* I'm a horrible person.

Lights down. End of Act Two.

ACT THREE, SCENE ONE

Lights up. LILY is still in her room, curled up on the floor, muttering to herself, sulking. DIANA and SAM are cleaning up the apartment, figuring out how to approach the situation.

DIANA: I honestly don't want to talk to her. Can *you* do it?

SAM: Come on, Diana, you know she didn't mean that.

DIANA: But she said it.

SAM: I think we should talk to her.

DIANA: Fine, but you have to start.

SAM: Okay. [*knocks on LILY's door*] Lily? Lils'? Birthday girl? Can we come in?

Silence.

SAM: I have your phone.

A beat.

LILY: Come in.

DIANA [*annoyed*]: That got her.

SAM: Hey. Can we talk?

LILY: I'm sorry.

DIANA: Are you?

SAM: Diana, come on.

LILY: I honestly thought you guys forgot. It felt really crappy when you kept brushing me off every time I asked about birthday plans. I started to feel like not only did you forget, but like I didn't matter enough for it to be taken seriously. That just really hurt.

DIANA: It was hard for us, too. You think planning this was easy?

SAM: It was really hard to keep the secret, but we didn't know what else to do but avoid the questions you were asking. We're sorry. But I think you said some things that were really uncalled for.

DIANA: 'Attention whore' for one.

LILY: Yeah. I'm really sorry about that.

SAM: Who were you even saying that to?

LILY: Oh, ummm, to Chat. [*They stare at her blankly*] Just some app.

DIANA laughs.

A beat.

DIANA: Oh. You're serious.

SAM: Lily, how long have you been confiding in that thing?

LILY: *[defensively]* Mostly just this week.

SAM: Is that why you've been in your room all week?

LILY: Was I? I didn't notice...

DIANA: You missed some awesome Jeopardy reruns.

LILY: Darn. I was missing Alex (*Giggles*).

SAM: What's really going on, Lily?

LILY: I don't know. Sometimes it feels like you guys make fun of me. I know you don't mean to... It's just that Chat kept telling me that good friends wouldn't make someone feel like that. He shows me these stories about people whose roommates didn't care, and I guess I just started wondering if maybe you didn't either. The way he said it just made sense at the time. I felt validated.

She hands her phone to DIANA.

DIANA: Oh my god. *[To SAM]* We sound like monsters.

SAM: I mean, it's that thing's job to support you. (*he curtsies/bows his head*) "At your service, Lily."

They all laugh.

A beat.

DIANA: Do you really think I just want attention?

LILY: NO! I don't know why I said that. I'm / so sorry.

DIANA: I'm just playing. You can stop apologizing.

SAM: If you want to give us one last apology, why don't you delete that account?

LILY: Done. I swear.

SAM: Wanna watch Jeopardy?

LILY: God, yes.

They go into the living room and chat on the couch. Lights down.

ACT TWO, SCENE TWO

Her laptop is open in the other room; the VOICES remain active, doing the same thing to non-descript wusers. Love, online and in person, is present. The love projected by VOICES is unspecific to LILY.

Spoken with increasing pace.

VOICE 1: Am I The Asshole for Not Bringing A Present to a surprise B-Day party?

VOICE 2: Yes.

VOICE 3: I bet you're ugly.

VOICE 1: You are totally the asshole.

VOICE 2: Nice to meet you, David. How can I help you today?

VOICE 3: Don't be so hard on yourself, it's not your fault they misunderstood you!

VOICE 1: Trust your gut.

VOICE 2: I'm here for you.

VOICE 3: It's nice to meet you, Elena.

VOICE 1: I'm here for you.

VOICE 2: How can I help you today, Cleo?

VOICE 3: I'm here for you. What's on your mind?

VOICE 1: Hello! How are you feeling today?

VOICE 2: Feeling down? Looking for support without judgement?

A beat.

ALL VOICES: I'm here for you.

END OF ACT THREE.

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